

Snooping DRAGON

Delhi and Beijing may be talking peace, but war has been declared in cyberspace, as organised Chinese hackers target Indian computers with deadly digital weapons

By Sandeep Unnithan

It is October 3, 2010, the inaugural of the prestigious Commonwealth Games in Delhi. The games infrastructure has just squeaked past the finish line and the nation flags off the games in a spectacular sound and light show under a massive security umbrella. But there are problems. The ticketing for the games goes haywire and servers hosting the online registration crash. The games limp along and the nation is internationally embarrassed.

It sounds like a scenario straight out of *Die Hard 4* but isn't entirely far-fetched. Months ago, India's intelligence agencies tasked with cyber warfare detected Chinese hackers downloading Request for Proposals for the Commonwealth Games security architecture. "They obviously wanted to study the networks for vulnerabilities," says an official. Officially, India and China are at peace; both sides have been engaged in talks for over two decades even as soldiers on either side of the 3,350-km frontier eyeball each other. In the blurred boundaries of cyberspace,

however, a war has already broken out. Everyday dozens of cyber warriors from the Defence Intelligence Agency (DIA)—comprising officials from the army, navy and air force—and the National Technical Research Organisation (NTRO), India's technical intelligence organisation, learn about new weapons like "worms" and Remotely Activated Trojans (RATS). They are trained to watch for the enemy—Chinese hackers.

The cyber war on India began as a series of small attacks on the computers of the Ministry of External Affairs in April 2008 and in January and June 2009. The first major salvo was fired on December 15 last year when 450 government computers were attacked, including those of senior government officials in the Prime Minister's Office, including then National Security Adviser (NSA) M.K. Narayanan and Deputy NSA Shekhar Dutt and the chiefs of the navy, army and air force besides officials in the defence intelligence agencies. It was the single largest breach of the Indian defence establishment and the amount of information compromised was, in the words of an official, "phenomenal". It

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